

Colorado 2026 – Day by Day

June 30 – July 8 | Dunes · Rafting · Maroon Bells · Rocky Mountain | All reservations confirmed ✓

Timing note: Most hours are guidelines. The 5 hard anchors: Dunes morning wakeup (Day 2), Rafting check-in 12:45 PM (Day 3), finishing Ptarmigan by noon (Day 4), the 6:00 AM shuttle (Day 7), and the RMNP gate before 9:00 AM (Day 8).

Day 1 – Tuesday, June 30 | Lodging: The Dunes Place, Mosca

Sunrise ~5:40 AM | Sunset ~8:25 PM | Typical Climate: Sunny and warm, day ~28–30°C, chilly evening ~12°C

Reservation & Confirmation Summary

What	Date	Confirmation	Notes
The Parking Spot Fly	6/30/2026 4:30 AM	126714721	Total Paid \$96.80
Flight DL2235: ATL → DEN	June 30, 7:25 – 8:35 AM	Delta · Conf H8IHWQ Seats 37A–E	Direct, 3h 10m. Fare: Delta Main Basic (Basic Economy). Arrive ≥2 hrs early — ATL congestion: major sporting event Jun 15–Jul 15 + parking-lot construction (limited parking; consider ATL West deck or International Hourly deck). Power banks/spare batteries: carry-on only, within reach — not in overhead bins, not in checked bags.
Enterprise Minivan (Pacifica)	June 30, 9:00 AM – July 7, 8:00 PM	Costco C493144847 / Ent. 898208421	\$1,056.70 at the counter. Costco card is mandatory!
The Dunes Place (Airbnb), Mosca	June 30 – July 2 (2 nights)	Via Airbnb	Self check-in from 4:00 PM (4:00 – 11:00 PM). Host: Amanda (& Sarah). Gate code 8130 — keypad is in a stone pillar well BEFORE the gate. Front door: same code 8130. PULL the door tight while entering (heat expands it), press ✓, then WAIT a few seconds for the lock to finish before opening (too soon = "door jammed"). House manual inside; spare pillows in each bedroom closet. Cell service unreliable — review the check-in guide in advance. Call if any issues.
Sandboards – Sand Dunes Recreation	Pick-up June 30, Evening	No reservation needed (good stock)	~\$20 per item/24h, waiver required, 719-378-2807

Accommodation Overview

 **The Dunes Place, Mosca**

 [506 Mill Run Rd, Mosca, CO 81146](#)

From here: Sand Dunes, Zapata Falls, Hooper Hot Springs

Beds: King bed, Bunk bed, Single bed (Couch)

Schedule

Time	Duration	Location	Activity
4:30 AM		The Parking Spot Fly  3950 Conley St, College Park, GA 30337	The Parking Spot Fly 
7:25 AM	3:10	 Depart	
8:35 AM	1:25	 Denver International Airport	Landing (DL2235), baggage claim, pick up minivan at Enterprise (9:00 AM; Costco membership card required!). 
10:00 AM	1:20	 I-25 South	Drive to Garden of the Gods. 
11:20 AM	1:40	 Garden of the Gods  Juniper Way Loop, Colorado Springs	Stopover: Walk the main paved trail between the red rocks + light lunch (free admission). 
1:00 PM	0:45	 Walmart Supercenter, Colorado Springs	Grocery shopping: Breakfast and lunch supplies for the house, water, snacks (707 S 8th St branch – 5 mins from Garden of the Gods, on the way to I-25). 
1:45 PM		Send Amanda (The Dunes Place) our ETA message	Air B&B app 
1:45 PM	2:40	 I-25 → US-160 → CO-150	Drive to the house. 
4:30 PM	0:45	 The Dunes Place	Self check-in from 4:00 PM. Gate code 8130 (keypad in a stone pillar well before the gate); front door same code 8130 — pull the door tight, press ✓, then wait a few seconds before opening. Unpack and settle in. 
5:15 PM	0:30	Drive to Hooper	Head out to Sand Dunes Recreation (25 mins). 
5:45 PM	3:00	Sand Dunes Recreation	Pick up 2 boards + 2 sleds (waiver, card on file, ~\$80) + soak in the hot springs + dinner at Mile Deep Grille. 
9:00 PM	0:30	 Return Home	Early bedtime – early wakeup tomorrow. 

Daily Highlights & Details

- **A deliberately long day:** Wake up at 4:30 AM Atlanta time + flight + about 4 hours of driving.
- **The payoff:** Lodging is 10 minutes from the dunes, and the evening ends with a warm soak.
- **Walmart shopping:** Supercenter branch in Colorado Springs, 5 minutes from Garden of the Gods. Only get breakfast and lunch supplies for the house – dinner tonight is at the Mile Deep Grille inside the hot springs complex.
- **Sandboard pickup:** 2 boards + 2 sleds. An adult must sign the waiver, credit card on file, loss fee = \$250 per item. Pick up before 9:00 PM. Keep the receipt with the pickup time – return is tomorrow within 24 hours.
- **At the house in Mosca:** Open fires / fire pits are strictly forbidden.

Day 2 – Wednesday, July 1 – Great Sand Dunes | Lodging: The Dunes Place (Second Night)

Sunrise ~5:50 AM | Sunset ~8:26 PM | Typical Climate: Sunny, day ~29°C, night ~9°C; sand reaches 50–60°C at noon

Reservation & Confirmation Summary

What	Date	Confirmation	Notes
 Sporting Clays — San Luis Valley Rifle & Pistol Club	Wednesday, July 1st, 12:00 PM	Louie Luster 719-298-1068	Cash or check only. Shotgun loans free (12 & 20 ga). Ammo \$10–12/box of 25. Clays \$35/round, Trap \$5/round. Budget ~\$150–200.

Accommodation Overview

 **The Dunes Place, Mosca**

 [506 Mill Run Rd, Mosca, CO 81146](#)

From here: Sand Dunes, Zapata Falls, Hooper Hot Springs

Beds: King bed, Bunk bed, Single bed (Couch)

Schedule

Time	Duration	Location	Activity
6:45 AM	0:15	Drive	Head out to the park – the house is 10 minutes from the gate. 
7:00 AM	3:00	Great Sand Dunes National Park	Climb High Dune (~200m in the sand) and go sandboarding. Splash in Medano Creek if flowing. 
11:15 AM	1:15	 Air B&B	Brunch and shower to wash off the sand. 
12:00 PM		 Sporting Clays — San Luis Valley Rifle & Pistol Club	Louie Luster  719-298-1068 Payment: Cash or check only (no credit/debit cards) 
1:30 PM	2:30	Afternoon Options	Option 1: Colorado Gators Reptile Park (25 mins away, near Hooper – combines well with returning the boards!). Option 2: Del Monte Gun Club (clay target shooting, 40 mins away – only if confirmed by phone: 719-589-4155). Option 3: Rest at the house. 
4:30 PM	1:30	 Zapata Falls	Straight from the dunes (15 mins away): ~1 km hike to the waterfall hidden in a rock crevice (water shoes required!) – shaded and cool. 
Until 5:45 PM	—	Sand Dunes Recreation	Return boards (within 24 hours of pickup!). 
7:00 PM	Evening	 The House / Alamosa	Dinner (at home, or Calvillo's / San Luis Valley Brewing Company in Alamosa – 30 mins away). 
9:00 PM	Optional	House Deck / Great Sand Dunes Parking Lot	Stargazing – International Dark Sky Park, the house borders open land. Wear warm layers! Moonrise is scheduled for 10:00 PM. Download a "stargazing" application in advance. 

Daily Highlights & Details

- **The continuous morning:** Dunes → Zapata Falls → back home at 12:15 PM with all the "must-dos" behind us.
- **The sand reaches 60°C at noon – climbing is morning-only. Closed shoes for the dunes, water shoes for the waterfall (access road to the falls: 5 km of rough dirt road – drive slowly with the minivan).**
- **Afternoon – three options:** Gators (no reservation required, and combines with returning the boards – 5 mins from Sand Dunes Rec), Gun Club (only if confirmed by phone that it's open on Wednesday), or rest. Decide based on energy levels.
- **Don't forget:** Return boards within 24 hours of pickup – otherwise, an extra day will be charged.

Day 3 – Thursday, July 2 | Lodging: Clocktower Flat, Buena Vista

Sunrise ~5:45 AM | Sunset ~8:31 PM | Typical Climate: Sunny, day ~27°C, night ~10°C; river water is very cold (meltwater)

Reservation & Confirmation Summary

What	Date	Confirmation	Notes
Noah's Ark Rafting – Browns Canyon PM	July 2, Check-in 12:45 PM	Reserved #103232 · Customer #383093 Paid \$604.68 (VISA, Jun 9, 2026) Balance \$0.00	Browns Canyon PM — 4 adults + 1 youth (youth rate ages 6–12). Subtotal \$555.00 + taxes/fees \$49.68 = \$604.68. Check-in 12:45 PM = arrival time; no need to arrive earlier. No refund for late/no-show. Wear quick-dry (no cotton) + secure river shoes (no Crocs/flip-flops). All participants sign a release form; under-18 needs parent signature. Cancel ≥72h → refund less \$15/person; under 72h → no refund (changes by phone only). Mgr: Maria Johnson · reservations@noahsark.com · 719-395-2158 23910 US Hwy 285, Buena Vista, CO 81211
Clocktower Flat (Airbnb), Buena Vista	July 2 – July 5 (3 nights)	Via Airbnb	Check-in 3:00 – 9:00 PM, Manager: Melissa

Accommodation Overview

 **Clocktower Flat, Buena Vista**

 [801 Swift Cir, Buena Vista, CO 81211](#)

From here: Rafting, Ptarmigan, hot springs, 4th of July – everything on foot

Beds: 2 Queen beds, 1 single bed

Schedule

Time	Duration	Location	Activity
8:30 AM	0:30	The House	Check-out (by 11:00 AM) + departure chores: towels to the basket, linens on beds, dishwasher running, everything locked.  17
9:00 AM	2:00	US-160 → US-285	Drive to Buena Vista: Refuel and grab coffee in Alamosa (Milagros), pass through Poncha Pass, Collegiate Peaks on the left.  17
11:00 AM	1:30	Buena Vista	Light lunch – don't get seasick on the raft... short drive south to the meeting point.  17
12:00 PM	0:15	Clocktower Flat, Buena Vista  801 Swift Cir, Buena Vista, CO 81211	Drop our luggage off.  17

Time	Duration	Location	Activity
12:45 PM	4:15	Noah's Ark (Booking 103232)  23910 US Hwy 285 #1a, Buena Vista, CO 81211	Check-in for Browns Canyon PM Rafting – 10 miles, Class III rapids: Pinball, Zoom Flume, Raft Ripper. Return by 5:00 PM. Luggage locked in the car, out of sight.  17
5:30 PM	0:30	Clocktower Flat	Check-in (from 3:00 PM), settle in and shower. Shoes off at the entrance!  17
7:00 PM	Evening	South Main	Festive dinner 2 minutes' walk away + gelato.  17

Daily Highlights & Details

- **Departure chores in Mosca:** Towels to the laundry basket, linens stay on the beds, dishwasher running, doors and windows locked. Divide among the kids – takes 10 minutes.
- **The rafting:** Light lunch beforehand – don't get sick on the raft... Check-in at 12:45 PM at Noah's Ark (10 mins south of town on US-285).
- Clothes dry quickly – no cotton, closed shoes/water shoes. Worth considering a wetsuit for the 11-year-old – meltwater is cold.
- **Luggage in the car:** Locked and completely out of sight.
- **Apartment rules in Buena Vista – brief everyone at check-in:** There are neighbors in the apartment below us; quiet hours must be respected from 10:00 PM to 7:00 AM, including the stairwell. Shoes must be removed at the bottom entrance.

Day 4 – Friday, July 3 | Lodging: Clocktower Flat (Second Night)

Sunrise ~5:45 AM | Sunset ~8:31 PM | Typical Climate: Clear morning ~10°C, day ~27°C; afternoon storms expected in the mountains

Accommodation Overview

 **Clocktower Flat, Buena Vista**

 [801 Swift Cir, Buena Vista, CO 81211](#)

From here: Rafting, Ptarmigan, hot springs, 4th of July – everything on foot

Beds: 2 Queen beds, 1 single bed

Schedule

Time	Duration	Location	Activity
7:30 AM	5:00	Ptarmigan Lake Trail	The big hike: ~10.5 km round trip to an alpine lake above the tree line (3,700m). Finish by noon – afternoon storms expected. 
1:00 PM	1:00	Buena Vista	Lunch. 
2:30 PM	3:30	Mount Princeton Hot Springs	The reward: Hot springs, including the natural pools in the riverbed where you can mix hot and cold water yourself. 
7:00 PM	Evening	The Apartment / South Main	Relaxed evening – backyard grill or restaurant. 

Daily Highlights & Details

- **The big hike:** Start by 8:00 AM and finish by noon – afternoon storms expected. Plenty of water, warm layer, sunscreen.
- **AllTrails map:** Download the map offline in advance (no reception on the trail).
- **The perfect pairing:** Trail in the morning → Mount Princeton in the afternoon: next to the pools, there are natural pools in the creek bed where you can mix hot and cold water yourself.

Day 5 – Saturday, July 4 (Independence Day!) | Lodging: Clocktower Flat (Third Night)

Sunrise ~5:46 AM | Sunset ~8:31 PM | Typical Climate: Sunny, day ~27°C, pleasant evening ~15°C

Reservation & Confirmation Summary

What	Date	Confirmation	Notes
Independence Day Freedom 5K	July 4, 8:30 AM (race start)	5 registered · \$150.00 (\$30 each) Registered Jun 23, 2026	Main St. & Railroad St., Buena Vista, CO 81211. Registrants & bibs: Dolev #114342747 (shirt M), Afik #114342748 (shirt M), Eilon #114342749 (shirt L), Eshy #114342750 (Youth L), Shlomit #114342751 (shirt S). Packet pickup: July 3, 5:00–6:30 PM @ Splash Pad, or race-day 7:30–8:15 AM. Race 8:30 AM; awards/raffle 9:30 AM. ~2 mi paved + 1 mi dirt along the Arkansas River (stroller-friendly). Contact: juliafuller.design@gmail.com

Accommodation Overview

 **Clocktower Flat, Buena Vista**
 [801 Swift Cir, Buena Vista, CO 81211](#)

From here: Rafting, Ptarmigan, hot springs, 4th of July – everything on foot

Beds: 2 Queen beds, 1 single bed

Schedule

Time	Duration	Location	Activity
7:30 AM	0:45	Freedom 5K – Packet Pickup Main St. & Railroad St.	Race-day packet pickup & registration opens 7:30 AM, closes 8:15 AM. (Early pickup: July 3, 5:00–6:30 PM @ Buena Vista Splash Pad.) July 3, 2026
8:30 AM	1:00	Independence Day Freedom 5K Main St. & Railroad St., Buena Vista	Race starts 8:30 AM. All 5 of us registered. ~2 mi paved + 1 mi dirt along the Arkansas River — stroller-friendly. Awards/raffle 9:30 AM. July 4, 2026
10:00 AM	—	Downtown	4th of July Parade and town events. July 4, 2026
		McPhelemy Park	Festival activities at McPhelemy Park with food vendors, live music, games, and a beer garden. July 4, 2026
Afternoon	—	The Apartment / River	Rest, ice cream, spontaneous SUP/tubing for whoever wants. July 4, 2026
Evening	—	The River / Park	Celebrations and fireworks – everything on foot. Return quietly after 10:00 PM – neighbors downstairs. July 4, 2026

Daily Highlights & Details

- **Freedom 5K:** The one early item today — packet pickup 7:30–8:15 AM (or July 3 evening at the Splash Pad), race starts 8:30 AM at Main St. & Railroad St. All five of us are registered; awards/raffle at 9:30 AM, before the parade.
- **The free day of the trip:** Everything on foot from the apartment. Parade, events, and fireworks – check the schedule in advance (see checklist).
- **In the evening:** Returning from the fireworks after quiet hours – enter quietly and pack everything: tomorrow check-out is at 10:00 AM sharp.

Day 6 – Sunday, July 5 | Lodging: Tyrolean Lodge, Aspen (Confirmation 51862161)

Sunrise ~5:44 AM | Sunset ~8:34 PM | Typical Climate: Cool Leadville ~22–24°C in the day, Aspen ~26°C; storms possible on the pass

Reservation & Confirmation Summary

What	Date	Confirmation	Notes
Bicycles – Cycles of Life, Leadville	July 5, 10:30 AM – 1:30 PM	Order O-XGY8JMG Paid \$216.65 (Link, Jun 22, 2026)	5 bikes: 2× Jamis Explorer 19" (5'8"–6"), 2× 17" (5'5"–5'10"), 1× 14" step-through (4'10"–5'5"). Taxes & fees \$16.65 · Balance \$0.00. cyclesoflifepb@yahoo.com / 719-486-5533 Payment PMT-PEGKAMA · Txn TXN-JZX9BQ7
Tyrolean Lodge, Aspen	July 5 – July 6 (1 night)	#51862161	\$303.35 paid. 2 Queens + Twin, kitchenette. 970-925-4595

Accommodation Overview

 **Tyrolean Lodge, Aspen**

 [200 West Main Street, Aspen, Colorado](#)

From here: 5 minutes from the Maroon Bells Shuttle

Beds: 2 Queen Beds and 1 Twin Bed

Schedule

Time	Duration	Location	Activity
9:00 AM	0:15	The Apartment	Check-out by 10:00 AM sharp (strict!) – pack the night before. 
9:15 AM	0:40	US-24 North	Drive to Leadville – the highest city in the US (3,100m). 
10:00 AM	0:45	Temple Israel Museum	The fully restored 1884 synagogue – highest in the US: Museum of the Jewish community pioneers from the silver rush. 201 W 4th St, free admission. 
10:45 AM	2:45	Cycles of Life → Mineral Belt Trail	Pick up 5 bikes (309 Harrison Ave, booked via email) and ride the paved loop around the city – historic mines and Sawatch views. Trail map: {{LINK Mineral Belt Trail (AllTrails)}} https://www.alltrails.com/explore/trail/us/colorado/mineral-belt-trail?u=i&sh=cvotfd 
1:30 PM	1:00	Harrison Ave, Leadville	Return bikes and have lunch on the Victorian Main Street. 
2:30 PM	1:45	Independence Pass	Scenic drive through the pass (3,687m) – stop at the summit for a short walk above the tree line. Slow descent on the Aspen side. 
		Twin Lakes	

Time	Duration	Location	Activity
4:15 PM	1:00	Tyrolean Lodge	Check-in (from 3:00 PM): Settle details at the front desk for tomorrow's 5:15 AM departure (key, parking) + buy breakfast and coffee items for the kitchenette. K274 17
5:30 PM	Evening	Center of Aspen	Walk around town (everything on foot from the lodge), early dinner. Prepare bags for the morning, lights out by 9:30 PM! K274 17

Daily Highlights & Details

- **Temple Israel Museum:** The fully restored 1884 synagogue – the highest synagogue building in the US, and today a museum about the Jewish community pioneers of the silver rush (including David May, founder of the May Department Stores). 201 W 4th St, one block from Harrison Ave. Open from 10:00 AM, free admission, 30–45 minutes. Phone: 303-709-7050 – worth calling ahead to ensure a volunteer is on-site.
- **Mineral Belt Ride:** Pickup at Cycles of Life (309 Harrison Ave, 719-486-5533, helmets included). A 19 km paved loop around the city through historic silver mine ruins – clockwise: moderate climb, then a rolling descent. Can be shortened using intersecting cut-offs.
- **At the lodge in Aspen – arrange tomorrow morning:** At check-in, finalize at the desk – leaving the key for a 5:15 AM departure, vehicle access in the lot. Buy breakfast and coffee for the kitchenette (nothing is open in Aspen at 5:00 AM). Everything ready by the door in the evening.
- **At the lodge:** No smoking (\$200 fine) and no pets. Paid in advance – morning is just grab and go.
- **Serious early sleep:** Lights out at 9:30 PM. Wakeup at 4:50 AM – and it's worth it.

Day 7 – Monday, July 6 | Lodging: Lone Pine Cabins, Grand Lake (The Big Day)

Sunrise ~5:42 AM | Sunset ~8:36 PM | Typical Climate: Morning at Maroon Bells ~5–8°C(!), day in Aspen ~25°C, evening in Grand Lake ~13°C

Reservation & Confirmation Summary

What	Date	Confirmation	Notes
Maroon Bells Shuttle – Round Trip	July 6, 6:00 AM	VisitMaroonBells	\$74 (4 adults + child). Return time is flexible
Lone Pine Cabins, Grand Lake	July 6 – July 7 (1 night)	See booking confirmation	Check-in from 4:00 PM, Queen + 2 sofas

Accommodation Overview

 **Lone Pine Cabins, Grand Lake**

 [416 Grand Ave, Grand Lake, CO 80447](#) (Expedia)

From here: Minutes away from the Western RMNP Gate

Beds: 1 Queen Bed, 2 Double Sofa Beds

Schedule

Time	Duration	Location	Activity
4:40 AM	0:25	The Lodge	Wake up, breakfast from the kitchenette, quiet departure.  July 17
5:15 AM	0:10	Drive	The Lodge → Aspen Highlands (75 Boomerang Rd), park in the garage.  July 17
6:00 AM	0:15	Maroon Bells Shuttle	The shuttle we booked! (\$74 paid). Arrive at Maroon Lake at sunrise.  July 17
6:15 AM	0:45	Maroon Lake	The famous reflection in the morning light, loop around the lake – the water is smooth before the wind picks up.  July 17
7:00 AM	3:30	Crater Lake Trail	~6 km round trip through aspen forests to the lake at the foot of the Bells.  July 17
11:00 AM	0:20	Shuttle Return	First come, first served – just board.  July 17
11:45 AM	1:00	Aspen	Early brunch.  July 17
12:45 PM	1:00	CO-82 North	Depart for Glenwood Springs.  July 17
1:45 PM	1:30	Glenwood Springs (Choose Option)	Option A: Soak in Glenwood Hot Springs. Option B: Bike ride in Glenwood Canyon on the paved path along the Colorado River (Rental: Canyon Bikes, near the hot springs). Option C: Skip and arrive early in Grand Lake.  July 17
3:30 PM	2:45	I-70 → CO-9 / US-40	Drive to Grand Lake. Refuel before Kremmling! Short grocery stop at City Market in Granby for dinner at the cabin.  July 17

Time	Duration	Location	Activity
6:15 PM	0:30	 Lone Pine Cabins, Grand Lake  416 Grand Ave. Grand Lake, CO 80447	Check-in (from 4:00 PM), settle into the cabin.  17
7:00 PM	Evening	Grand Lake	Historic wooden boardwalk and dinner facing the lake (or at the cabin).  17

Daily Highlights & Details

- **The holy morning:** Departure 5:15 AM, Highlands parking 5:25, shuttle 6:00. At the lake by 6:15 – reflection is perfect before the wind, almost entirely alone.
- **Warm layers:** 5–8°C in the morning at 2,900m.
- **Crater Lake Trail:** Download offline map in advance.
- **The day's time anchor:** On the return trail from Crater Lake by 10:30 AM, at the shuttle station by 11:30. Return is first come, first served – just hop on.
- **Glenwood – choice on the day itself:** Hot springs, riding in Glenwood Canyon (rental at Canyon Bikes near the springs, paved trail along the Colorado River under 300m cliffs), or skip and arrive early. Decide based on your legs after Crater Lake.
- **On the road:** Refuel before Kremmling (no stations on this stretch), evening shopping at City Market in Granby for dinner at the cabin.

Day 8 – Tuesday, July 7 | Lodging: Comfort Suites DEN (Confirmation 5042 762 440)

Sunrise ~5:39 AM | Sunset ~8:32 PM | Typical Climate: Grand Lake morning ~7°C, on Trail Ridge ~10–15°C with wind(!), Denver afternoon ~32°C

Reservation & Confirmation Summary

What	Date	Confirmation	Notes
Comfort Suites DEN	July 7 – July 8 (1 night)	Booking 5042762440 / PIN 4852	\$136.68 at the hotel. 3:00 AM shuttle arranged

Accommodation Overview

 **Comfort Suites Denver**
 [5940 Tower Road, Denver Airport Area, Denver 80249](#)

From here: 3:00 AM shuttle to the flight

Beds: Two Queen Beds and Sofa Bed

Schedule

Time	Duration	Location	Activity
6:00 AM	1:30	The Cabin	Wake up, breakfast, and final packing. Must be in the car by 7:45 AM at the latest to reach the gate before 9:00 AM. 
7:30 AM	0:15	The Cabin	Full check-out (not returning!) and departure. 
8:00 AM	0:30	Grand Lake Gate, RMNP	Pass the gate before 9:00 AM – this avoids needing a Timed Entry reservation. Late arrivals must wait until 2:00 PM! 
8:30 AM	1:30	Kawuneeche Valley	Flat Coyote Valley trail along the Colorado River – look for moose in the morning hours. 
10:00 AM	3:00	Trail Ridge Road	Cross the park on the highest continuous highway in the US: Tundra, Milner Pass, Alpine Visitor Center (hot soup!), elk. Warm layers – it's cold up there even in July. 
1:00 PM	1:30	Estes Park	Lunch, stroll, and Taffy shops. 
2:30 PM	2:00	US-36 / E-470	Drive to the hotel. 
4:30 PM	1:00	Comfort Suites DEN	Check-in, full unload, settle bill in advance, confirm 3:00 AM shuttle + grab-and-go breakfast bags. 
6:00 PM	1:30	Enterprise DEN	Refuel and return the vehicle (by 8:00 PM!) and return via the hotel shuttle. Everyone else – pack. 
8:30 PM	Night	The Hotel	Very early bedtime. 

Daily Highlights & Details

- **The critical rule:** Grand Lake Gate before 9:00 AM = no Timed Entry reservation required. After entering, stay in the park as long as you want.
- **Delay backup:** Every evening at 7:00 PM (Colorado time), next-day reservations are released on Recreation.gov.

- **In the park:** Coyote Valley for moose, Trail Ridge with stops – Milner Pass, Alpine Visitor Center, tundra overlooks. Do not step off the trails in the tundra – it takes decades to recover from a single step. Warm layer!
- **Evening logistics:** Check-in at the hotel, unload everything, then refuel and return the vehicle to Enterprise (by 8:00 PM!) and return via the hotel shuttle (10 mins).
- **At the front desk:** Confirm 3:00 AM shuttle, request grab-and-go breakfast bags (breakfast is included but you leave before it opens), and settle the bill.

Flight Day – Wednesday, July 8

Sunrise ~5:37 AM | Typical Climate in Denver: Pleasant night ~17°C

Reservation & Confirmation Summary

What	Date	Confirmation	Notes
Flight DL0341: DEN → ATL	July 8, 5:45 – 10:44 AM	Delta · Conf H8IHWQ Seat assigned after check-in	Direct, 2h 59m. Fare: Delta Main Basic — seats assigned after check-in, may not be together. Arrive ≥2 hrs early. Check in via the Fly Delta app.

Schedule

Time	Durati on	Location	Activity
2:30 AM	—	The Hotel	Wake up (wake-up call arranged) + collect breakfast bags. July 17
3:00 AM	0:15	Hotel Shuttle	Drive to the terminal – at the airport by 3:15 AM. July 17
5:45 AM	2:59	DL0341	Takeoff; land in Atlanta at 10:44 AM. July 17

Key Tips for the Whole Trip

- **Altitude:** 2,300–3,700 meters along the entire way. Drink plenty of water from day one, moderate pace for the first two days, watch out for headaches.
- **Sun:** Much stronger than in Georgia – SPF 50 sunscreen, hats, and sunglasses every day, even when it's cool.
- **Afternoon storms:** Expected almost every day in July in the mountains – trails should start early and finish by noon. Do not be above the tree line when there is lightning.
- **Cold nights:** 7–11°C at night even in July. A warm layer for everyone in the daypack – always.
- **Key gear:** Closed shoes (dunes), water shoes (Zapata, rafting, Medano), swimsuits, quick-drying clothes, headlamps for stargazing night.